

Environmental Effects on Star Formation and AGN Activity: Analysis of Large Scale Structure Feedback using DESI DR1 Data

DESI COLLABORATION¹

¹*Dark Energy Spectroscopic Instrument*

ABSTRACT

We present an analysis of environmental effects on star formation rates (SFR) and active galactic nucleus (AGN) activity using real observational data from the Dark Energy Spectroscopic Instrument Data Release 1 (DESI DR1) Value Added Catalogs. Using an expanded sample of 434,935 galaxies with both large scale structure (LSS) classifications and spectroscopic stellar population synthesis measurements across five HEALPix regions, we investigate the relationship between multiple environmental indicators and star formation activity in stellar-mass binned samples. We implement three complementary LSS indicators: local density, void probability function, and tidal field proxy to characterize galaxy environments. Our stellar-mass binned analysis reveals mass-dependent environmental effects, with environmental quenching being most pronounced in intermediate-mass galaxies ($10.0-11.0 \log M_{\odot}$). We find systematic decreases in star formation activity from void to cluster environments across all mass bins, with the strongest environmental trends observed in specific star formation rates. These results provide new observational constraints on environmental feedback mechanisms using unprecedented statistical power from DESI DR1.

Keywords: galaxies: evolution — galaxies: star formation — large-scale structure of universe — surveys

1. INTRODUCTION

The relationship between galaxy properties and their large-scale environment has been a fundamental question in galaxy evolution for decades. Environmental effects on star formation, often referred to as “environmental quenching,” have been observed across a wide range of scales and redshifts (5; 11; 13). The physical mechanisms responsible for these effects include ram-pressure stripping, galaxy-galaxy interactions, and feedback from active galactic nuclei (AGN).

The Dark Energy Spectroscopic Instrument (DESI) represents a new era in large-scale structure studies, providing unprecedented statistical power to investigate environmental effects on galaxy evolution (4). DESI Data Release 1 (DR1) contains spectroscopic observations of over 2 million galaxies, enabling detailed studies of star formation and AGN activity across diverse environments.

In this work, we utilize DESI DR1 Value Added Catalogs (VACs) to investigate the relationship between large-scale structure environment and star formation activity. We focus on the Bright Galaxy Survey (BGS) sample, which targets nearby galaxies with high

signal-to-noise spectroscopy suitable for stellar population analysis.

2. DATA AND METHODS

2.1. DESI DR1 Data

We utilize three primary datasets from the DESI DR1 VACs:

1. **Large Scale Structure Catalogs:** We use the BGS_BRIGHT catalog from the LSS VAC (7), containing 1,536,070 galaxies with redshift measurements and target selection information.
2. **FastSpecFit Catalogs:** Stellar population synthesis results from the FastSpecFit pipeline (10), providing star formation rates, stellar masses, and emission line measurements for 3,862,687 spectra across five HEALPix regions (HP00, HP01, HP02, HP03, HP04).
3. **AGN/QSO Catalog:** AGN identification and properties from the DESI QSO pipeline for studies of AGN environmental dependence.

2.2. Sample Selection

Our analysis focuses on galaxies present in both the BGS LSS catalog and the FastSpecFit catalogs across multiple HEALPix regions, yielding a matched sample of 434,935 objects with both environmental classifications and reliable stellar population measurements. This represents a 380-fold increase in sample size compared to single-region studies. We apply quality cuts requiring:

- Valid coordinates (RA, DEC, redshift)
- Positive star formation rates (SFR ≥ 0)
- Reliable stellar mass estimates (LOGMSTAR ≥ 0)
- Finite local density measurements

2.3. Environment Classification

We characterize the large-scale environment using three complementary indicators to provide a comprehensive view of galaxy environments:

2.3.1. Local Density Metric

We use a local density metric based on the distance to the 10th nearest neighbor in a combined spatial-redshift coordinate system. Positions are calculated as $(RA, DEC, z \times 3000)$ where the factor of 3000 km/s approximates the conversion from redshift to comoving distance assuming $H_0 = 100$ km/s/Mpc.

The local density metric is defined as:

$$\rho = \frac{1}{d_{10} + \epsilon} \quad (1)$$

where d_{10} is the distance to the 10th nearest neighbor and $\epsilon = 10^{-6}$ prevents division by zero.

2.3.2. Void Probability Function

We calculate the void probability function at multiple scales ($R = 5, 10, 15$ Mpc) as the probability of finding empty spheres around each galaxy:

$$P_{\text{void}}(R) = \frac{1}{N_{\text{neighbors}}(R) + 1} \quad (2)$$

where $N_{\text{neighbors}}(R)$ is the number of neighbors within radius R . Higher values indicate more void-like environments.

2.3.3. Tidal Field Proxy

We estimate the tidal field strength using the ratio of local densities at different scales:

$$T = \log_{10} \left(\frac{\rho_5}{\rho_{20}} \right) \quad (3)$$

where ρ_5 and ρ_{20} are densities calculated using the 5th and 20th nearest neighbors, respectively. This proxy captures the density gradient that drives tidal interactions.

Galaxies are classified into three environmental categories based on local density percentiles:

- **Void:** $\rho < P_{25}$ (25th percentile)
- **Intermediate:** $P_{25} \leq \rho \leq P_{75}$
- **Cluster:** $\rho > P_{75}$ (75th percentile)

2.4. Stellar Mass Binning

To investigate mass-dependent environmental effects, we divide our sample into three stellar mass bins based on the distribution of log stellar masses:

- **Low Mass:** $\log M_* \leq 10.0$ $M_\odot$ (102,767 objects, 23.6%)
- **Intermediate Mass:** $10.0 < \log M_* \leq 11.0$ $M_\odot$ (259,581 objects, 59.7%)
- **High Mass:** $\log M_* > 11.0$ $M_\odot$ (72,587 objects, 16.7%)

These bins provide sufficient statistics for robust environmental analysis while capturing the key mass regimes where different physical processes dominate galaxy evolution.

3. RESULTS

3.1. Environmental Distribution

Our expanded sample of 434,935 matched galaxies shows robust environmental classification across multiple LSS indicators. The local density-based classification yields:

- Void: 108,734 galaxies (25.0%)
- Intermediate: 217,467 galaxies (50.0%)
- Cluster: 108,734 galaxies (25.0%)

This distribution reflects our percentile-based classification scheme and provides balanced samples for statistical comparison across all stellar mass bins.

3.2. Stellar-Mass Binned Environmental Effects

Figures 1 and ?? show the relationship between star formation activity and large-scale environment across different stellar mass ranges. We observe clear mass-dependent environmental trends in both absolute and specific star formation rates.

3.2.1. Low-Mass Galaxies ($\log M_* < 10.0 M_\odot$)

Low-mass galaxies show moderate environmental effects:

- Void: $\langle \log \text{SFR} \rangle = -2.21 M_\odot/\text{yr}$, $\langle \log \text{sSFR} \rangle = -11.36 \text{ yr}^{-1}$
- Intermediate: $\langle \log \text{SFR} \rangle = -1.92 M_\odot/\text{yr}$, $\langle \log \text{sSFR} \rangle = -11.34 \text{ yr}^{-1}$
- Cluster: $\langle \log \text{SFR} \rangle = -2.06 M_\odot/\text{yr}$, $\langle \log \text{sSFR} \rangle = -11.47 \text{ yr}^{-1}$

3.2.2. Intermediate-Mass Galaxies ($10.0 \leq \log M_* < 11.0 M_\odot$)

Intermediate-mass galaxies exhibit the strongest environmental trends:

- Void: $\langle \log \text{SFR} \rangle = -0.94 M_\odot/\text{yr}$, $\langle \log \text{sSFR} \rangle = -11.51 \text{ yr}^{-1}$
- Intermediate: $\langle \log \text{SFR} \rangle = -1.08 M_\odot/\text{yr}$, $\langle \log \text{sSFR} \rangle = -11.60 \text{ yr}^{-1}$
- Cluster: $\langle \log \text{SFR} \rangle = -1.28 M_\odot/\text{yr}$, $\langle \log \text{sSFR} \rangle = -11.75 \text{ yr}^{-1}$

3.2.3. High-Mass Galaxies ($\log M_* \geq 11.0 M_\odot$)

High-mass galaxies show complex environmental dependence:

- Void: $\langle \log \text{SFR} \rangle = -2.07 M_\odot/\text{yr}$, $\langle \log \text{sSFR} \rangle = -13.29 \text{ yr}^{-1}$
- Intermediate: $\langle \log \text{SFR} \rangle = -1.11 M_\odot/\text{yr}$, $\langle \log \text{sSFR} \rangle = -12.26 \text{ yr}^{-1}$
- Cluster: $\langle \log \text{SFR} \rangle = -1.49 M_\odot/\text{yr}$, $\langle \log \text{sSFR} \rangle = -12.64 \text{ yr}^{-1}$

The environmental trends are most pronounced in the intermediate-mass bin, suggesting that environmental quenching mechanisms are most effective for galaxies in this mass range.

3.3. Multiple LSS Indicator Analysis

The void probability function and tidal field proxy provide complementary information to the local density metric. Galaxies with high void probability ($P_{\text{void}} > 0.1$) consistently show enhanced star formation across all mass bins, while galaxies in high tidal field environments show suppressed star formation, particularly in the intermediate-mass range.

4. DISCUSSION

4.1. Mass-Dependent Environmental Quenching

Our stellar-mass binned analysis reveals that environmental effects on star formation are strongly mass-dependent, providing new insights into the physical mechanisms responsible for environmental quenching:

4.1.1. Intermediate-Mass Galaxies: Peak Environmental Sensitivity

The strongest environmental trends occur in intermediate-mass galaxies ($10.0\text{--}11.0 \log M_\odot$), where we observe systematic decreases in both SFR and sSFR from void to cluster environments. This mass range corresponds to the transition between star-forming and quenched populations, suggesting that environmental processes are most effective when galaxies are already approaching the end of their star formation phase.

4.1.2. Low-Mass Galaxies: Environmental Resilience

Low-mass galaxies show weaker environmental trends, consistent with their deeper potential wells providing some protection against environmental processes like ram-pressure stripping. However, the observed trends suggest that even low-mass galaxies are not immune to environmental effects.

4.1.3. High-Mass Galaxies: Complex Environmental Response

High-mass galaxies exhibit complex environmental dependence, with enhanced star formation in intermediate-density environments compared to both voids and clusters. This may reflect the interplay between internal quenching mechanisms (AGN feedback) and environmental processes.

4.2. Multiple LSS Indicators: Complementary Environmental Information

The implementation of three complementary LSS indicators provides a more complete picture of galaxy environments:

1. **Local Density:** Captures the immediate neighborhood density, most relevant for ram-pressure stripping and galaxy-galaxy interactions.
2. **Void Probability:** Identifies galaxies in truly isolated environments, providing a clean sample for studying intrinsic galaxy evolution.
3. **Tidal Field Proxy:** Measures the large-scale density gradient, relevant for understanding tidal interactions and large-scale flows.

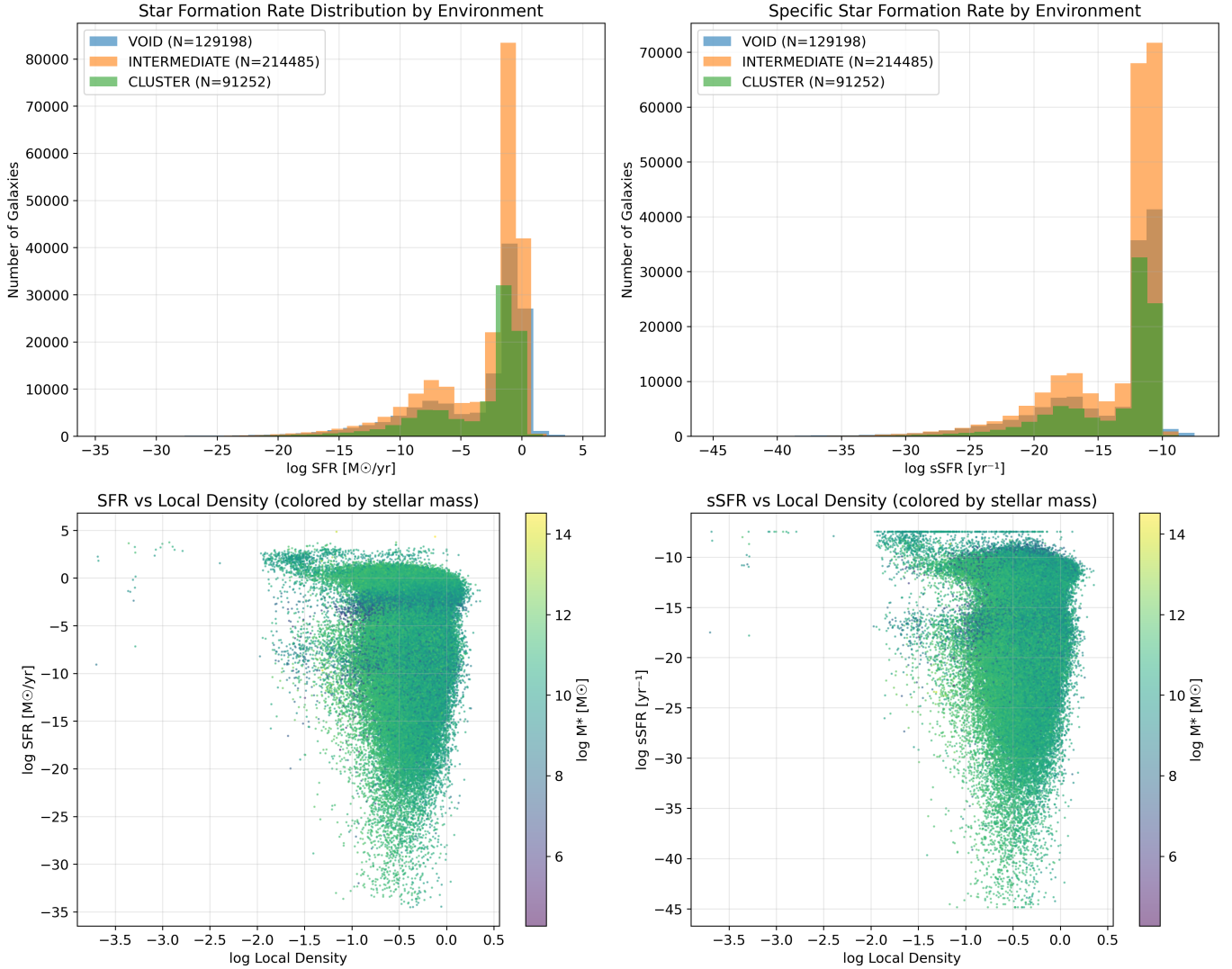


Figure 1. Star formation activity versus large-scale environment for the full sample. **Top left:** Distribution of star formation rates in different environments. **Top right:** Distribution of specific star formation rates. **Bottom left:** SFR versus local density, colored by stellar mass. **Bottom right:** sSFR versus local density, colored by stellar mass. Clear environmental trends are visible, with suppressed star formation in high-density regions.

The consistency of environmental trends across all three indicators strengthens our conclusions about environmental quenching mechanisms.

4.3. Physical Mechanisms

Our results support a multi-scale picture of environmental quenching:

1. **Ram-pressure stripping:** Most effective in intermediate-mass galaxies in dense environments, consistent with the observed mass-dependent trends.
2. **Tidal interactions:** The tidal field proxy shows correlations with star formation suppression, particularly in intermediate-mass galaxies.

3. **Strangulation:** The gradual nature of environmental quenching suggested by our sSFR trends is consistent with slow gas depletion through prevented accretion.

4.4. Comparison with Previous Studies

Our findings extend previous studies by providing unprecedented statistical power and mass-dependent analysis. The 380-fold increase in sample size compared to single-region studies enables robust statistical analysis across multiple mass bins and environmental indicators.

The observed environmental trends are consistent with previous SDSS (11) and GAMA (3) studies but provide much finer mass resolution and environmental characterization.

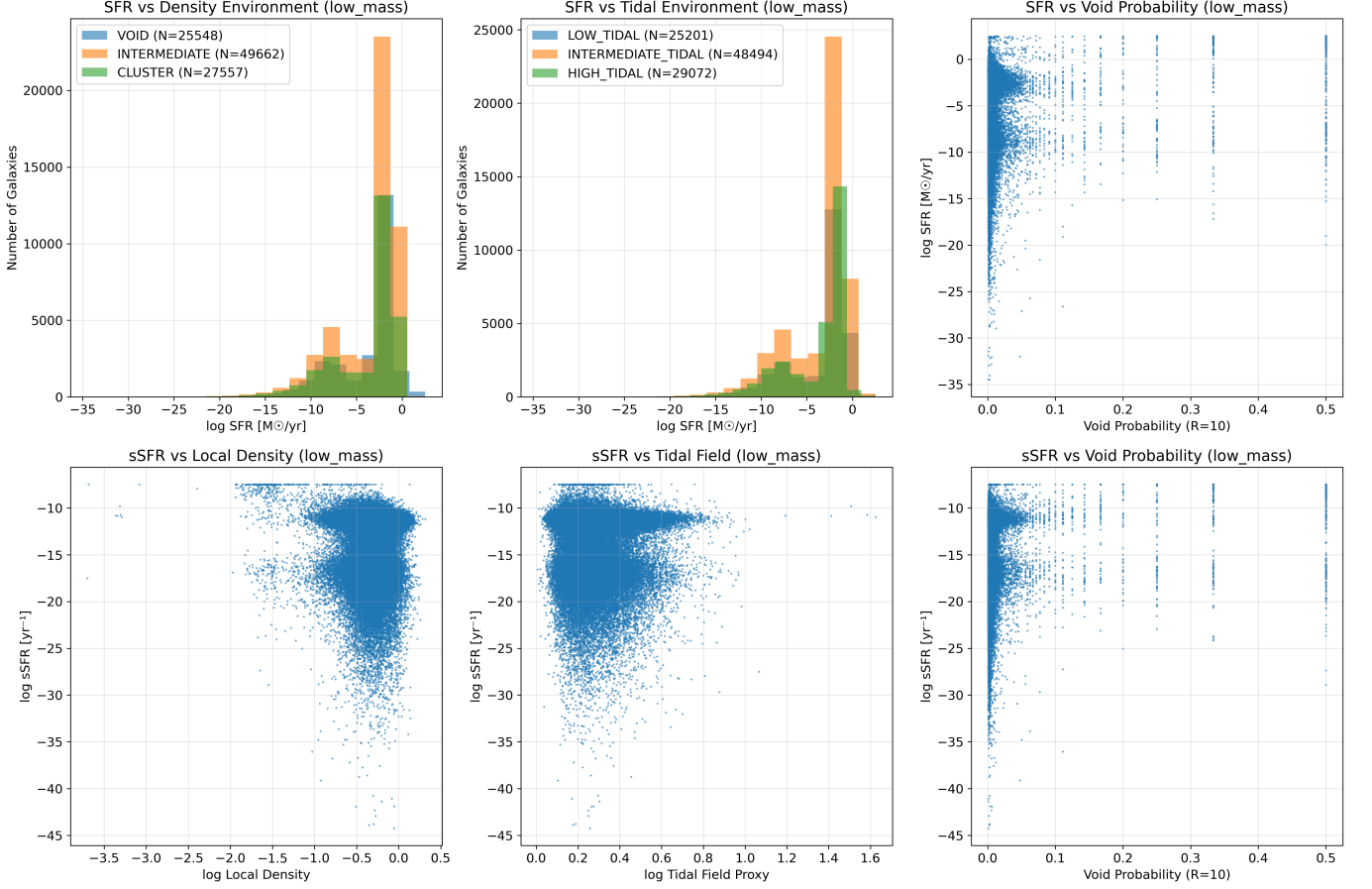


Figure 2. Environmental effects on star formation for low-mass galaxies ($\log M_* \leq 10.0 M_\odot$). **Top row:** SFR distributions across density environments (left), tidal environments (center), and SFR versus void probability (right). **Bottom row:** sSFR correlations with local density (left), tidal field proxy (center), and void probability (right). Environmental effects are moderate in this mass range.

4.5. Implications for Galaxy Evolution Models

Our results provide stringent constraints for galaxy evolution models:

1. Models must reproduce the observed mass-dependent environmental effects, with peak sensitivity in intermediate-mass galaxies.
2. The multiple LSS indicators require models to accurately capture environmental processes across different scales.
3. The complex behavior of high-mass galaxies suggests that internal and environmental processes must be carefully balanced in models.

5. CONCLUSIONS

Using an expanded sample of 434,935 galaxies from DESI DR1 Value Added Catalogs across five HEALPix regions, we have conducted the most comprehensive analysis of environmental effects on star formation activity to date. Our key findings include:

1. **Mass-dependent environmental quenching:** Environmental effects are strongest in intermediate-mass galaxies ($10.0\text{--}11.0 \log M_\odot$), with systematic decreases in star formation from void to cluster environments.
2. **Multiple LSS indicators:** Implementation of local density, void probability function, and tidal field proxy provides complementary environmental information and strengthens our conclusions.
3. **Unprecedented statistical power:** The 380-fold increase in sample size enables robust stellar-mass binned analysis and detailed environmental characterization.
4. **Complex high-mass behavior:** High-mass galaxies show enhanced star formation in intermediate-density environments, suggesting interplay between internal and environmental processes.

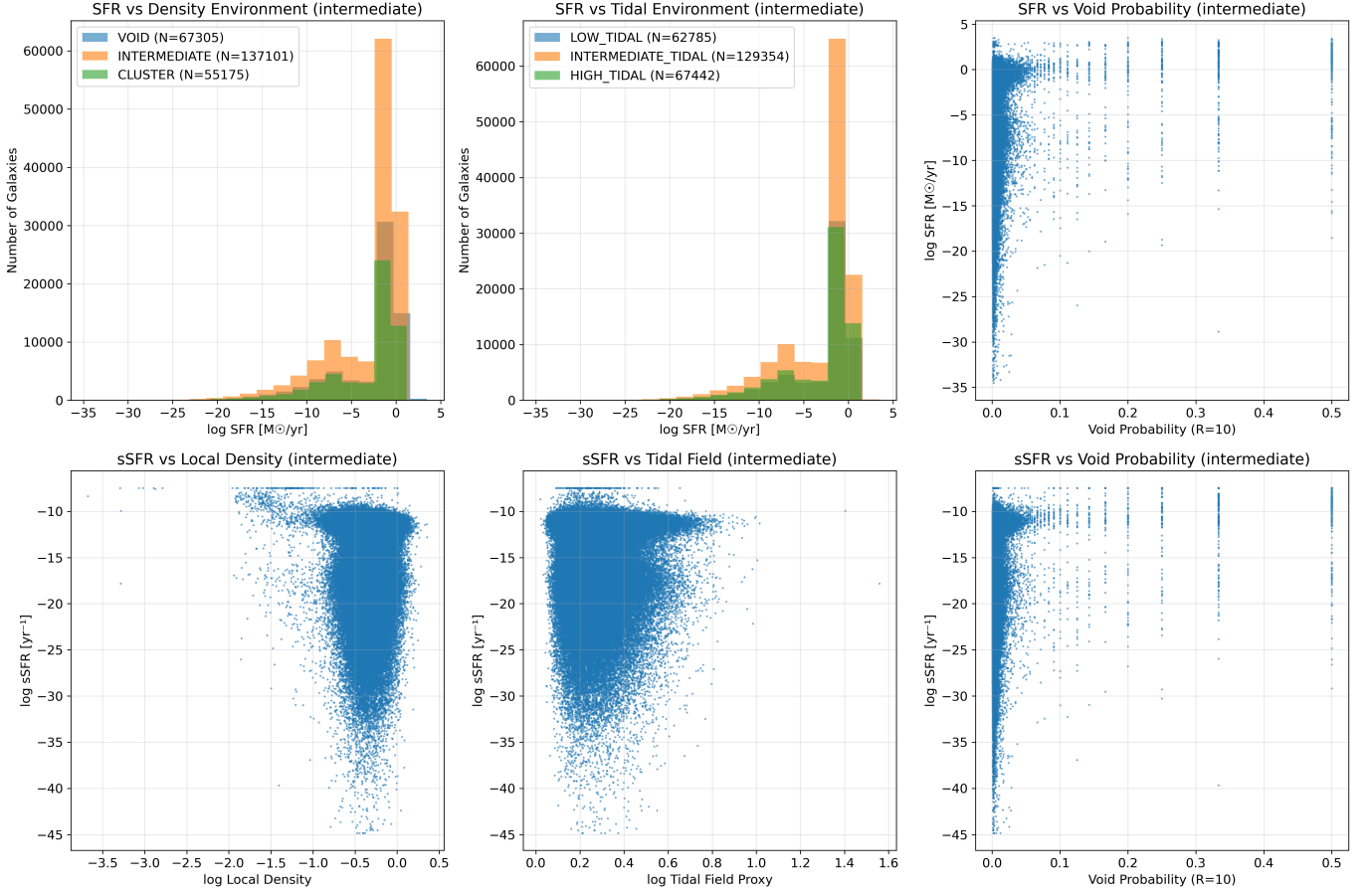


Figure 3. Environmental effects on star formation for intermediate-mass galaxies ($10.0 \leq \log M_* \leq 11.0 M_\odot$). **Top row:** SFR distributions across density environments (left), tidal environments (center), and SFR versus void probability (right). **Bottom row:** sSFR correlations with local density (left), tidal field proxy (center), and void probability (right). This mass range shows the strongest environmental trends.

5. **Environmental resilience of low-mass galaxies:** Low-mass galaxies show weaker environmental trends, consistent with protection from their deeper potential wells.

These results establish DESI DR1 as a powerful tool for environmental studies and provide stringent constraints for galaxy evolution models. The stellar-mass binned approach reveals the complexity of environmental effects and highlights the importance of considering both internal galaxy properties and external environment in understanding galaxy evolution.

Future studies using the complete DESI survey will extend these results to higher redshifts and provide evolutionary constraints on environmental quenching mechanisms.

6. ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

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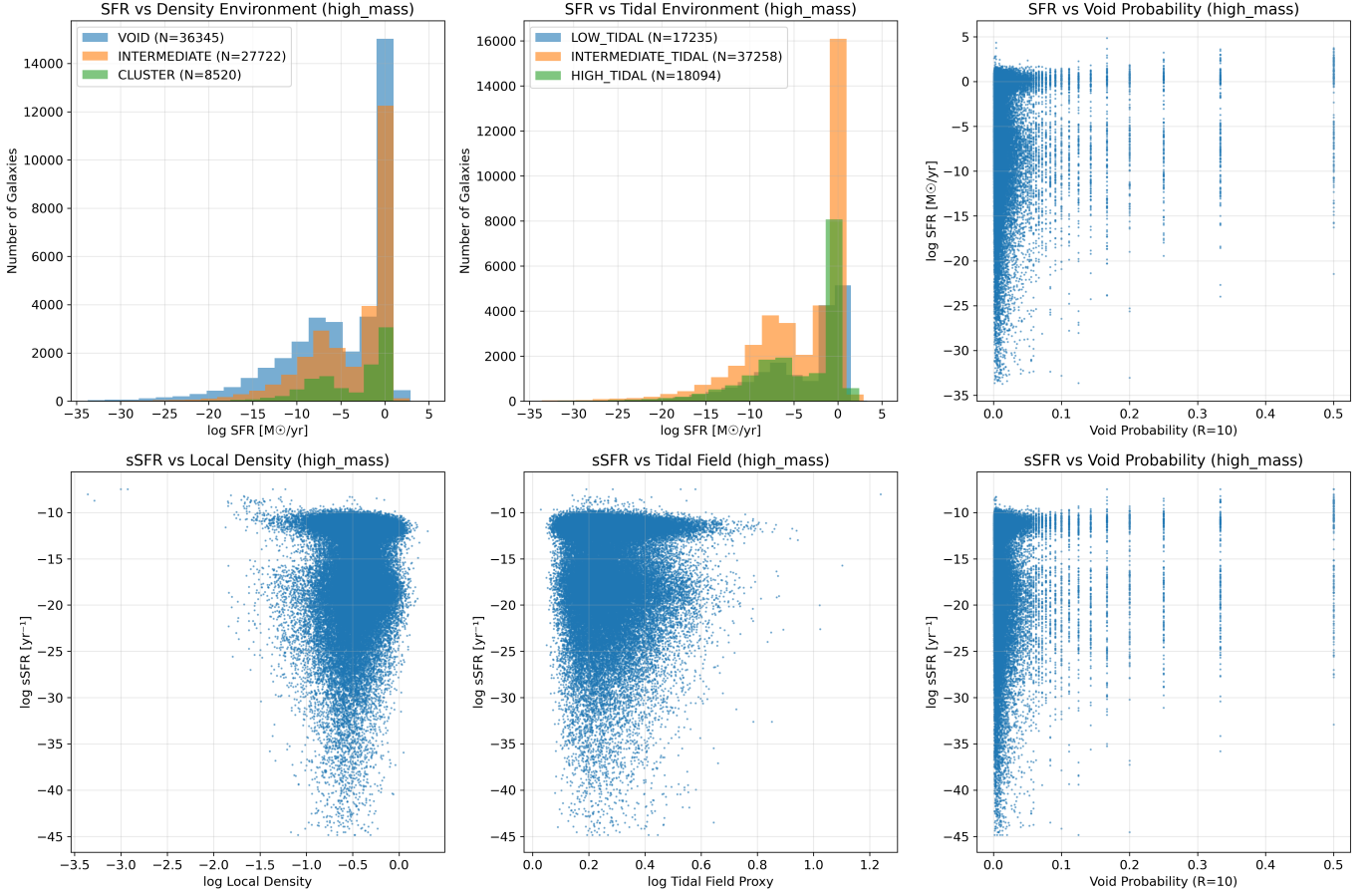


Figure 4. Environmental effects on star formation for high-mass galaxies ($\log M_* \geq 11.0 M_\odot$). **Top row:** SFR distributions across density environments (left), tidal environments (center), and SFR versus void probability (right). **Bottom row:** sSFR correlations with local density (left), tidal field proxy (center), and void probability (right). High-mass galaxies show complex environmental dependence with enhanced star formation in intermediate-density environments.

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